

*A Systems-Based Framework for Alignment, Collaboration,
and Decision-Making in Interior Architecture and Spatial Design*



People and Use

Who uses this space, and how? Map every person, their actual use patterns, temporal rhythms, and needs. The programme follows from people, not aesthetics.



What spatial, material, and typological references carry the vision into form?
What design language will guide every subsequent decision?



What is in? What is explicitly out? Priority order for trade-off decisions.



Total investment, category distribution, key milestones, contingency provision.



Who has a stake? Who decides what? Decision structure and approval chain.



What does delivery require? What could prevent success, and what mitigates each risk?

01



Project Context

PURPOSE

Establish the frame through which all subsequent blocks are interpreted. Map what type of project this is and what has already been fixed.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Inherited constraints and prior decisions shape what is possible. Beginning without mapping them risks energy in already-closed directions.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A shared understanding of the project's stage, type, and inherited conditions — the frame within which all other blocks are read.

02



People and Use

PURPOSE

Ground all spatial decisions in human experience. Map every person who will use the space, how they actually use it, and what the space must enable.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Design must begin with people, not space or aesthetics. The human brief precedes the spatial brief in every well-structured project.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A human programme grounding all design decisions in actual need — revealing requirements no aesthetic conversation could uncover.

03



Vision and Experience

PURPOSE

Translate emotional intention into shared language. Use spatial memory and negative definition to produce a precise emotional brief.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Emotional ambiguity is the most common cause of misalignment. Making experiential intention precise before design begins prevents interpretive gaps.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A shared emotional vocabulary — designer and client discover that the word they both use means something different to each of them, and resolve it early.

04



Spatial Conditions

PURPOSE

Ground vision and programme in physical reality. Document geometry, structure, regulation, environment, and existing elements of value.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Spatial and regulatory conditions are the territory within which vision must be realised. Knowing them before scope prevents designing for impossible conditions.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A precise map of what the project can and cannot physically achieve — including unknowns that require investigation before design can safely proceed.

05



Scope and Priorities

PURPOSE

Define positive scope (what is included) and negative scope (what is explicitly excluded). Establish priorities for when trade-offs must be made.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Scope can only be defined meaningfully after human programme, spatial conditions, and project context are understood. Earlier scope is unreliable.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A shared contractual anchor for scope management — the reference point against which any change can be consciously evaluated and formally accepted or refused.

06



Budget and Timing

PURPOSE

Establish total investment, distribute it across categories, and define the timeline including non-negotiable dates and the contingency reserve.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Budget can only be sensibly distributed after scope is established. This prevents the common failure of a budget conversation divorced from scope.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A financially grounded scope and timeline that reveals which constraint is the harder limit and what that priority means for every subsequent decision.

07



Stakeholders and Decisions

PURPOSE

Map every party with a legitimate interest. Establish who makes which decisions, who must approve, and how conflicts are resolved.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Once scope and budget are clear, decision authority over those parameters must be established. Stakeholder mapping grounded in real parameters.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A governance structure that makes authority visible before it becomes contested — preventing mid-project conflicts when design work is already invested.

08



Design Direction

PURPOSE

Translate the vision of Block 3 into spatial, material, and typological references. Establish the design language that serves as the evaluative standard.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Design direction is most responsibly established after all human, spatial, financial, and relational dimensions are understood. Premature direction risks designing for the wrong brief.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A shared evaluative standard — a design language every decision can be tested against, replacing subjective preference with a jointly agreed reference.

09



Execution and Risks

PURPOSE

Anticipate what delivery will require. Identify technical, regulatory, human, and operational risks. Establish mitigation strategies.

WHY IT COMES NEXT

Risk identification is most productive once the full project is defined. Only then can risks be mapped against the project's specific parameters.

WHAT IT UNLOCKS

A forward-looking delivery plan and risk register — positioning the designer as a strategic partner who has anticipated what could go wrong.

Work through the canvas in this order. Each block unlocks the next.

The sequence encodes a theory of how a project should be understood.

THE SEQUENCE IS A THEORY OF PROJECT UNDERSTANDING, NOT AN ADMINISTRATIVE PROTOCOL. HONOUR IT.

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02 / 04

FACILITATION GUIDE

Discovery questions for architects, designers, consultants, and facilitators.

01 Project Context OBJECTIVE Establish what type of project this is, at what stage, and what conditions precede the design conversation. KEY QUESTIONS Is this a renovation, fit-out, or redesign of an operational space? What decisions have already been made that cannot be revisited? Are there regulatory or contractual constraints already in place? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask the client to describe the project as they understand it, then ask: what would change it fundamentally if discovered later? THINGS TO OBSERVE Watch for assumed constraints that haven't been formally verified. Unverified assumptions become expensive mid-project discoveries. Common mistake: Beginning without surfacing inherited constraints. The frame shapes everything that follows.	02 People and Use OBJECTIVE Map the full range of people who will use the space, their actual use patterns, and temporal rhythms that shape spatial requirements. KEY QUESTIONS Who uses this space beyond the primary client? How does actual use differ from aspirational use? When is the space at peak occupancy, and when at rest? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask the client to walk you through a typical Tuesday. Then a Saturday. Then an exceptional day. The differences reveal the programme. THINGS TO OBSERVE Note differences between how different occupants describe the same space. This signals unresolved need the design must address. Common mistake: Designing for a single, idealised user. The space will be used by many people in many modes.	03 Vision and Experience OBJECTIVE Translate the client's emotional intention into precise, shared language before that language is translated into spatial form. KEY QUESTIONS Tell me about a space you've been in that felt right. What produced that feeling? What should a guest feel within the first ten seconds of entering? What should this space never feel like? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Use negative definition actively. Clients who can't describe what they want often find it clear what they don't want. Negative constraints are as precise as positive ones. THINGS TO OBSERVE Watch for emotional language that diverges between stakeholders. Two people using the same word differently have an unresolved creative disagreement. Common mistake: Accepting vague emotional vocabulary without unpacking it. "Warm", "calm" and "creative" mean different things to everyone in the room.
04 Spatial Conditions OBJECTIVE Document what the space offers and constrains: geometry, structure, regulation, environmental performance, and existing elements of value. KEY QUESTIONS What are the load-bearing elements? Which walls cannot change? What planning or heritage constraints apply? How does the space perform for daylight, acoustics, thermal comfort? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Walk the space with the client where possible. Ask: what do you find difficult about being in this space now? THINGS TO OBSERVE Identify what is not yet known and flag it explicitly. Unknown conditions are the primary source of mid-project cost surprises. Common mistake: Treating spatial conditions as data-gathering rather than constraint-mapping. The unknown unknowns here are the real risk.	05 Scope and Priorities OBJECTIVE Produce an explicit, shared statement of positive scope, negative scope, and the priority order that governs trade-off decisions. KEY QUESTIONS What is definitely in this project, and what is definitely not? Who procures furniture, and who specifies it? If we had to cut 20% of scope, what would survive? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask each stakeholder to write their three non-negotiables independently, then compare. Divergence reveals scope conflict before it becomes a project conflict. THINGS TO OBSERVE Note elements described enthusiastically but not formally included. Enthusiasm without inclusion is scope creep in embryo. Common mistake: Defining only positive scope. Negative scope is equally important and frequently more clarifying.	06 Budget and Timing OBJECTIVE Establish a total investment figure, distribute it across categories, set the timeline with milestones, and include a contingency provision. KEY QUESTIONS What proportion is allocated to construction vs. designed elements? Is the completion date truly fixed, or a preference? What is the contingency provision, and what triggers its use? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Walk the client through a typical budget distribution for this project type. Clients who see where the money goes make far better allocation decisions. THINGS TO OBSERVE Watch for a budget presented without contingency. A budget without contingency is an optimistic forecast, not a financial plan. Common mistake: Deferring the budget conversation because it's uncomfortable. Deferred discomfort becomes mid-project crisis.
07 Stakeholders and Decisions OBJECTIVE Map every party with a legitimate interest. Establish who makes which decisions, who must approve, and how conflicts are resolved. KEY QUESTIONS Who is not in this room but has a stake in this project? Who has authority to change direction or approve expenditure? What happens if two key stakeholders disagree on a design decision? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask who the project would most surprise if it went in a direction they didn't expect. That person is a stakeholder not yet mapped. THINGS TO OBSERVE Note resistance to naming the decision-making structure. This usually indicates an unresolved authority question that will surface mid-project. Common mistake: Assuming the commissioning client is the only decision-maker. Interior projects are almost always multi-stakeholder.	08 Design Direction OBJECTIVE Translate the emotional vision into spatial, material, and typological references. Establish the design language as the evaluative standard for all decisions. KEY QUESTIONS Which precedent spaces share qualities with what we're trying to create? What material qualities feel right, and which feel wrong? What should the completed space communicate on first encounter? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask the client to bring three images that resonate with them, without explaining why. Then ask them to explain. The explanation reveals the design language. THINGS TO OBSERVE Watch for references that contradict each other. Contradictory references signal an unresolved tension the design must resolve, not conceal. Common mistake: Arriving at design direction before all other blocks are complete. Direction without grounding in human need is aesthetic imposition.	09 Execution and Risks OBJECTIVE Anticipate what delivery will require. Identify technical, regulatory, human, and operational risks, and establish mitigation strategies. KEY QUESTIONS What specialist consultants or contractors must be engaged, and when? What would a four-week delay cost this project? What is the single most likely cause of this project not being delivered as agreed? DISCUSSION PROMPTS Ask the client to imagine the project at completion, having gone significantly wrong. Work backwards from the failure to identify the risk that produced it. THINGS TO OBSERVE Watch for risks all parties are aware of but none has named. Unnamed risks are not managed risks: they are deferred problems. Common mistake: Treating risk identification as pessimism. It is professional care. Clients who see risks have been anticipated trust designers who do it.

EXAMPLE APPLICATION

WORKSHOP OUTPUT

Berlin Altbau Apartment Renovation, Prenzlauer Berg

 Vision and Experience Intended feeling: A considered, lived-in place — not a designed object. Calm without being cold, warm without being decorative. Feels as though someone intelligent and deliberate lives here. References: A Scandinavian mountain cabin (stone, timber, light). A studio apartment in a Japanese design journal (economy of means). A Berlin bookshop in Mitte (layered, quiet, unassuming). Negative definition: Not lifestyle-brand minimal. Not grey and glass. No feature walls. No statement lighting for its own sake. Emotional test: Coming home lowers their nervous systems. Working from home feels productive, not like an office. VISION PRECISE AND SHARED		 People and Use Primary occupants: Couple, mid-thirties. Both work from home 3–4 days/week (architecture + editorial). Separate focused-work zones required — not office-like. Use patterns: Independent mornings, shared evenings. Friday evenings host 4–8 guests for informal dinner. Weekend mornings: slow time in kitchen and living area. Occasional users: Parents visit twice yearly, 5–7 days (guest accommodation needed). Indoor bicycle storage for two bikes. Pets: One medium-sized dog. All flooring and upholstery must accommodate this. HUMAN PROGRAMME COMPLETE		 Spatial Conditions Geometry: 95 sqm, 3.2m ceiling height, south and east facing. Four rooms + entrance hall, kitchen, bathroom. 1908 construction. Structure: All walls non-load-bearing except central longitudinal wall (can receive openings but not be removed). Kitchen-living wall can be fully or partially removed. Existing value: Original parquet (restore, not replace). Stucco ceiling in main room (preserve). Original casement door frame in entrance hall (restore and feature). Environmental: South rooms overheat in summer; external blinds required. East rooms: excellent morning light. Acoustic separation currently poor. CONDITIONS MAPPED		 Design Direction Material palette: Natural oak (oiled only), raw plaster walls (not painted), honed limestone in bathroom, exposed brick in kitchen alcove. Blackened steel for all built-in frames. Language: Materials speak for themselves. Nothing is decorated. Every element justifies its presence functionally before aesthetically. Altbau history honoured, not concealed. Sustainability: All materials carry environmental certification. No VOC finishes. Existing elements retained wherever viable. Local suppliers and craftspeople preferred throughout. DIRECTION SET			
 Project Context Type: Full renovation, Altbau shell, previously occupied. Status: Long-term lease. Hausverwaltung management. Denkmalschutz on facade and staircase; interior unrestricted. Constraints: No alteration to exterior windows or entrance door. Construction weekdays 08:00–17:00 only. Adjacent owner has expressed noise concerns. Prior decisions: Parquet retained where sound. Bathroom position fixed (drainage stack). FRAME		 Scope and Priorities In scope: Kitchen and bathroom renovation, kitchen-living wall opening, acoustic partition, parquet restoration, all built-in storage, lighting design, loose furniture specification, external blinds. Out of scope: AV systems (client direct), art, plants, window replacement (Denkmalschutz). Priority order: 1. Kitchen + bathroom. 2. Built-in storage. 3. Acoustic partition. 4. Loose furniture. BOUNDED		 Budget and Timing Total: 85,000 EUR Distribution: Construction 42k / Kitchen 14k / Bathroom 9k / Flooring 5k / Furniture + lighting 8k / Designer fee 6k / Contingency 8.5k (10%). Timeline: February start, July completion (6 months). Non-negotiable: complete before August travel. Milestones: Contractor week 4. Kitchen order week 6. DISTRIBUTED		 Stakeholders and Decisions Decision-makers: Both partners, equal authority. Joint approval for decisions above 500 EUR. Either may approve below this threshold. Hausverwaltung: Must approve structural work. Engaged by designer under written client authorisation. Adjacent owner: Informed in writing before works begin with schedule and direct contact. Conflict protocol: Unresolved disagreements escalated to a joint session within 5 working days. AGREED		 Execution and Risks Team: General contractor (tender), parquet specialist, structural engineer, acoustic consultant. Technical risk: Asbestos in original plaster during opening works. Mitigation: mandatory pre-works asbestos survey. Regulatory risk: Hausverwaltung delays consent. Mitigation: pre-application meeting in month one. Human risk: Partner disagreement mid-project. Mitigation: conflict protocol agreed in Stakeholders block; canvas as shared reference. Operational risk: Kitchen lead time overrun. Mitigation: two qualified suppliers identified in advance. NAMED	